CAPSTONE, PORTFOLIO & INTERVIEWS · LESSON 9 OF 10

# Career Readiness Check: Know Where You Stand Before You Apply

Use a structured self-check of eight readiness statements to see whether you are ready to apply for analyst roles, which topics to close first, and how to turn each gap into a short plan. Includes the scoring bands and a plan template.

Gap-fill lesson | 2026 | Beginner | 45 min

**By the end of this lesson you can**

- Answer the eight readiness statements honestly, with evidence
- Interpret the score and choose the next step
- Turn each gap into a specific, time-bound action
- Set a review date and measure progress

## Why a readiness check

Many people apply for jobs before they can do the work they will be asked to do, or they keep studying long after they are ready. A readiness check replaces a feeling ("I think I'm ready") with evidence ("I can write a window function from memory and I have two published projects"). It is a planning tool, not a judgement of your potential.

## The eight statements

Answer **yes** only if you could demonstrate the statement today, without notes, to someone who knows the subject.

| # | Statement | Evidence that proves it |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | I can write SQL joins, window functions and cohort queries from memory. | Write a cohort query on a sample database in 15 minutes |
| 2 | I can build a dashboard with a star schema and DAX measures. | A published report with at least eight measures and a data model diagram |
| 3 | I can clean data and explain every step. | A cleaning notebook or workbook, with the reasons for each change |
| 4 | I can explain a model's metrics to a non-technical person. | A two-minute explanation of MAE and R-squared for a manager, recorded |
| 5 | I have two published projects with READMEs. | Two links, each with a README that states the problem and the result |
| 6 | I can describe an ETL pipeline and its tests. | A diagram of a pipeline with the checks at each step |
| 7 | I can explain RAG and a basic agent. | A short explanation plus a working demo or a diagram of the loop |
| 8 | I can explain privacy basics for personal data. | A one-page summary of how you would handle customer data in a project |

## Scoring

| Yes answers | What it means | Next step |
|---|---|---|
| 10 or more of the 16 extended items (see below) | Ready to apply for analyst roles with a portfolio | Apply, keep one project in progress, and prepare for interviews |
| 7 to 9 | Close to ready | Complete the missing topics in the matching lesson and build one more project |
| Fewer than 7 | Build the foundations first | Return to the foundation topics in the roadmap and repeat the check in a month |

The eight statements above are a core check. For the 16-item version, add eight items that match your target role: for example, "I can write an Airflow DAG" for a data engineer, or "I can run a churn model with a validation set" for a data scientist. Score out of 16 and use the same bands.

::::warn Be honest with yourself A "yes" that depends on a tutorial you followed last week is not a yes. Ask: could I do this again tomorrow, without the notes? If the answer is no, mark it "not yet" and make it a task. ::::

## From gap to plan

For each statement you cannot yet say yes to, write one row of a plan:

| Gap | Action | Time | Evidence I will produce | Review date |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Window functions | Complete the window-function exercises, then solve five new problems without notes | 2 hours over two weeks | Five solved problems with explanations | Two weeks from today |
| Explaining metrics | Record a two-minute explanation of MAE and R-squared | 1 hour | Recording reviewed by a peer | One week from today |

Keep the plan to three gaps at a time. Too many gaps at once means none is closed.

## Reviewing progress

Repeat the check every four to six weeks. Expect the score to move up in steps, and expect a plateau when you are learning something hard. A plateau is not failure; it means you are working on the real difficulty. Share the result with a mentor or a study partner, and ask them to check one of your "yes" answers.

## Applying when you score well

When you are ready:

1. Choose three target roles and read five job descriptions for each. List the skills that repeat.
2. Match your two best projects to those skills, and put the matching skill first in your CV.
3. Prepare for the interview types in the earlier lessons: technical questions, scenarios and STAR answers.
4. Apply to a manageable number of roles each week, and track each application with its date and status.

INTERVIEW CORNER **"Are you ready for a data analyst job?"**

A strong answer names the evidence: "I have two published projects, one dashboard with a star schema and eight measures, and I can explain each measure's logic. I am working on window functions in SQL, and I am practising explanations for non-technical managers." This is honest, specific, and shows a plan.

::::key What to remember - Answer each statement with evidence, not a feeling. - Use the score bands to choose the next step: apply, close gaps, or build foundations. - Turn each gap into a time-bound action with an evidence output. - Repeat the check every four to six weeks. ::::

## Quick quiz

5 questions · tap an answer to check it

**1. What is the test for a "yes" answer in the readiness check?**

A You have read about it

B You have watched a video about it

C You could demonstrate it today, without notes, to someone who knows the subject

D You have a certificate

**Answer: C.** Demonstration is the standard, not familiarity.

**2. A candidate scores 8 of 16. What is the sensible next step?**

A Apply to everything

B Close the missing topics and build one more project

C Stop studying

D Repeat the check the same day

**Answer: B.** The middle band calls for targeted gap closure and one more project.

**3.** Why limit the plan to three gaps at a time?

A It is required by the scoring

B Too many gaps at once mean none is closed

C Three is a legal minimum

D It makes the plan look shorter

**Answer: B.** Focus makes progress visible.

**4.** What is a good piece of evidence for "I can explain RAG and a basic agent"?

A A list of buzzwords

B A short explanation plus a demo or diagram of the loop

C A job title

D A social media post

**Answer: B.** Evidence shows understanding, not familiarity.

**5.** How often should the readiness check be repeated?

A Once a year

B Every four to six weeks

C Never, once passed

D Every day

**Answer: B.** Regular review shows progress and reveals plateaus.

EXERCISE **Score yourself and write the plan**

Answer the eight statements with evidence, add eight items for your target role, and score out of 16. Write a plan for your three biggest gaps, each with an action, a time, an evidence output and a review date. Share the plan with one person and ask for a challenge to one of your "yes" answers.

**Show solution (worked answer)**

Hints: a "yes" with no evidence attached should be marked "not yet". For the review date, put a specific calendar date in your diary. The evidence output should be something another person could check.

## Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.